

The Tell: Which Pitch-Sequencing Giveaways Survive New Games

Introduction. Advance reports flag sequencing tells (“after a slider he doubles up”), and clubs act on them. Prior work predicts pitches out of sample; none tests whether the cues in advance reports survive new games. We ask how much the previous pitch gives away beyond count and batter hand, how much cues survive, whether predictability costs pitchers, and whether it changed in 2026, the first automated ball-strike (ABS) challenge season.

Methods. 2,049,352 Statcast pitches, 2024–2026 (1,793 pitcher-seasons with 250+ pitches). Nested models predict pitch type from batter hand, then count, then previous pitch, on unseen games. TELL is the previous-pitch gain per pitcher-season, over pitches after a plate appearance’s first. A cue is the count, hand and previous pitch that most shifts one pitch type’s share. Each pitcher’s top cue is found in April–June (or 2025), scored only on later games, raw and net of the league. Outcome regressions fix pitcher-season and pitch type $\times$ count $\times$ hand, controlling velocity; a second adds the previous pitch’s result. An in-season alarm multiplies game-by-game permutation e-values within count and hand. 2025–26 changes are compared with 2024–25 (TELL paired by pitcher).

Results.

- Each pitcher’s top April–June cue (110 of 598 pitchers) shifts the next-pitch share by 26 points when found and 10 on July–September games (95% CI 7–13; 78% same direction, chance 50%; Figure 1B). Net of the league, 7 points (70%). Repeat-pitch cues hold 14 points, others 8.
- The 10 largest 2025 cues all kept direction in 2026, shrinking 44 to 29 points (Table 1).
- In 2025, hand and count carry 102 and 58 millibits; the previous pitch adds 12.8. With it, guessing the likeliest pitch is right 0.8 points more often, 7 against Dylan Cease.
- TELL’s within-season split-half reliability is 0.75; across seasons, $r = 0.22$ (count gain: 0.62).
- Predictable pitches are associated with better outcomes, not worse. Within pitcher-season, from predictability’s 10th to 90th percentile, whiffs per swing rise 1.1 points ($t = 6.8$) and pitchers save 0.26 more runs per 100 pitches ($t = 4.7$); controlling the previous pitch’s result, 0.9 and 0.24.
- The alarm fired for 25% of 2025 pitchers (median 436 pitches), 1% of cue-free controls, and 1.6% of count-responsive simulations (Figure 1C).
- In 2026 the called zone’s top was 1.2 inches lower (2024→25: 0.2), but TELL changed only +0.01 millibits (95% CI -1.86 to $+1.88$; 2024→25: -0.49).

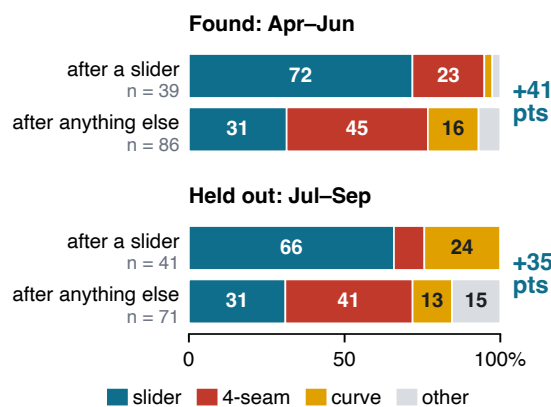
Conclusion. Sequencing tells are real but shrink by a third to three-quarters when held out, and predictability is far less stable across seasons than within one. Advance scouts should validate cues on held-out games, discount them, and use the alarm to trigger review.

Table 1. Top 2025 cues (50+ pitches; 25+ in 2026). Shift: share after the cue minus after other previous pitches, same count and hand.

Pitcher	Situation	Next pitch	Found 2025	Held out 2026	<i>n</i> 2026
Dylan Lee	0-1 vs RHB, after slider	slider	+66	+44	62
Jack Leiter	1-2 vs LHB, after 4-seam	4-seam	-46	-17	39
Kevin Gausman	0-2 vs LHB, after 4-seam	4-seam	+45	+25	74
Chris Sale	0-1 vs RHB, after slider	4-seam	-44	-25	111
Gregory Soto	0-1 vs RHB, after sinker	sinker	+43	+22	48
Matthew Boyd	2-2 vs RHB, after change	4-seam	+41	+28	54
Hunter Brown	0-1 vs RHB, after sinker	sinker	+40	+36	50
Kris Bubic	1-0 vs RHB, after 4-seam	4-seam	+38	+43	36
Drew Rasmussen	1-2 vs LHB, after cutter	cutter	-38	-26	51
Dustin May	1-2 vs LHB, after sweeper	sweeper	-37	-23	31

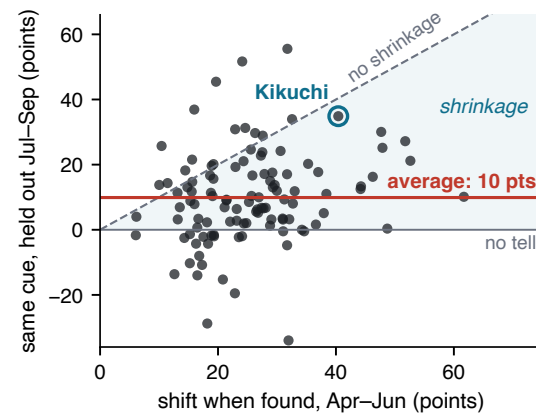
A A cue that held up: Kikuchi, 2025, 1-0 vs RHB

next-pitch mix after a slider vs after anything else



B Every pitcher's top cue, held out (*n* = 110)

found 26 pts, held out 10; same direction 78% (no tell: 0, 50%)



C An in-season alarm

permutes pitch order within count and batter hand, game by game

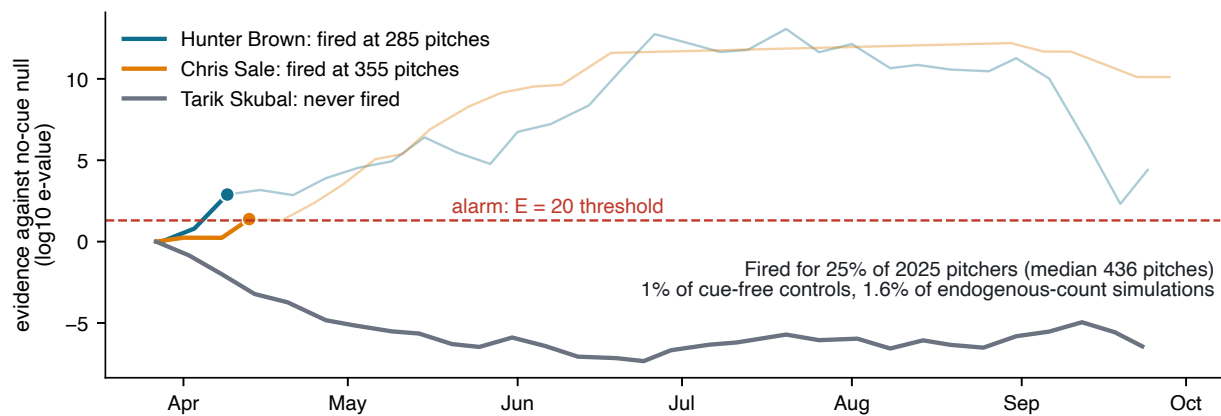


Figure 1. (A) Apr-Jun 2025 vs Jul-Sep. (B) Top Apr-Jun cues (30+ pitches each way), re-scored Jul-Sep (10+). (C) Alarm paths; faded after firing.